

Impact of Psychological Counselling on the Economic Survival of Families in Isi-Uzo LGA of Enugu State: A 21st Century Approach

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Abstract

The family is an important constituent of the society, therefore its economic survival has a significant impact on how far society can progress in its economy and development. Regretfully, majority of families are experiencing challenges in her economy, this calls for psychological intervention (counselling). This research focused on the impact of psychological counselling for economic survival in the Family: A 21st century Approach. This study adopted a quasi-experimental research design. The participants of the study were two hundred and twenty-four (224) families in Isi-Uzo Local Government Area in Enugu State. The participants were randomly selected. The instrument used for data collection is titled Walsh Family Resilience Questionnaire (WFRQ). This instrument was validated and the reliability coefficient computed as 0.85. Five sessions of treatment were held with the participants. The data were analyzed using descriptive and inferential statistics. The results of the study revealed a significant impact of psychological counselling on the economic survival of the family. The study therefore recommends the need for counsellors to be involved in addressing the various financial challenges in the family to enhance their financial resilience, and work towards long-term stability and prosperity. However, tailoring strategies to the unique circumstances of each family is key to creating a sustainable and effective plan for economic survival in the 21st century.

Keywords: Psychology, Counselling, Economic Survival, Family, century Approach

Introduction

The majority of social organizations are structured around the family. Although its form and nature may differ among civilizations, it serves the same essential

purposes. Family is an institution for carrying out essential production, consumption, reproduction and accumulation functions that are associated with social and economic impairment of

individuals and societies. The Family has been defined in various ways by different authors. According to Mondal (2020), it is an intimate group made up of people related to one another by bonds of blood, sexual mating or legal ties. It can be described as the smallest and most basic social unit which is also the most important group in any society. The family can also be seen as a social group made up of a father, mother and children. It is the most immediate group a child is exposed to and has tremendous influence in the life of a person from birth until death. It plays a great role in the life of every individual as it cares and empowers.

In this study, family is a social unit that consists of individuals related by blood, marriage or adoption, who shares a common residence, resources, and emotional bonds. The family is responsible for all round survival of an individual in every situation. In this hard economic time, families must adopt coping strategies in order to survive (Kolowale, 2021). Therefore, upholding families' values and providing psychological counselling to prevent families from going into extinct are essential. Psychologically, living in economic stress causes the affected to be exhausted more often than persons who don't (Mood & Jonsson, 2018). Socially, the poor have limited access to

good hygiene and sanitation, they are susceptible to poor health, school dropout, family issues and family conflicts (Mood & Jonsson, 2022).

Statement of the problem

Economic survival in families has detrimental psychosocial implication, such as rise in social vices, aggression and decline in economic development. Families who are affected by this are most implicated in this because; they are disadvantaged and lack the resources to impact positively on the economy. For example, they lack access to finance and knowledge of enterprise. They are the ones who scramble for reliefs and wait un-end for promises of loans from Government, Aids Agencies and Cooperative societies. Their insufficient education and skills development hinder their ability to compete in the job market and adapt to changing economic conditions which is responsible for their continuous struggle to make ends meet, lacking a stable income to cover basic needs leading to economic stress. Economic survival is a problem because it affects not only financial stability but also mental and physical well-being, relationships, and overall quality of life. Therefore, this study aims at determining the impact of psychological

counselling on the economic survival of families in Isi-Uzo LGA of Enugu State.

Objectives of the study

The main objective of this study was to determine the impact of Psychological counselling on the economic survival of the families in Isi-Uzo LGA of Enugu State. Specifically, the study sought to:

1. Find out the significant impact of psychological counselling on economic survival of the families in Isi-Uzo LGA of Enugu State.
2. Establish the effect of education on the economic survival of families in Isi-Uzo LGA of Enugu State.

Research questions

The study was guided by two research questions

1. Is there any significant impact of psychological counselling on the economic survival of families in Isi-Uzo LGA of Enugu State?
2. How does education affect the economic survival of families in Isi-Uzo LGA of Enugu State?

Hypotheses

This study was guided by two hypotheses

H01: There is no significant impact of psychological counselling on the economic survival of families in Isi-Uzo LGA of Enugu State.

H02: There is no significant effect of education on the economic survival of families in Isi-Uzo LGA. of Enugu State.

These hypotheses were tested at 0.05 level of significant.

Concept of Psychological counselling

Psychological counselling, also known as psychotherapy, is a type of treatment that involves talking with a mental health professional to learn how to manage and overcome various mental health issues (American Psychological Association, 2024). The term can mean different things to different people, but in general, it is a process people seek when they want to change something in their lives, or simply explore their thoughts and feelings in more depth. Counselling is a dynamic and purposeful relationship between two people who approach a mutually defined problem, with mutual consideration of each other to the end that the younger or less mature or more troubled of the two is aided to a self-determined resolution to his or her problem.

Psychological counselling may involve a series of educational intervention

services involving cognitive, Affective and behavioural approaches. It is usually provided by a skilled personnel or professional counsellor to a group or an individual for the purpose of helping the recipient improve his or her well-being, for example by adopting better rational ideas, attitudes, coping skills and better perception. It is believed that counselling process helps the client to attain rational behaviour, happiness and self-actualization (Agbaje, 2015). Through directive teaching and learning experience, the client becomes aware of the need to retain knowledge and maintain a rational and logical pattern of thinking that improves self.

According to Agbaje (2015), counselling has the potential to change negative behaviour to positive one. It helps individuals to make changes in their attitudes and perception. It helps people to attain rational behaviour. Counselling helps individuals to cope with stress and anxiety (Lambert, 2017). The vulnerable groups need counselling to help them increase their resilience in the face of disadvantaged life conditions. According to Idika and Dada (2016) and Dannan (2018) when youths are empowered, their energies are redirected from crime and social vices to economic activities and industry. A crucial factor in

the success of psychological counselling is establishing a strong therapeutic relationship between the patient and the therapist.

Economic survival counselling is a specialized form of guidance and support provided to individuals or families facing financial challenges and uncertainties. It is a holistic and client-centered approach that considers the unique circumstances of each individual or family. It involves a collaborative and therapeutic process where trained professionals help clients navigate economic difficulties, make informed financial decisions, and develop strategies for achieving financial stability.

Economic survival is a comprehensive concept that encompasses various strategies and approaches individuals and families can employ to navigate financial challenges, ensure stability, and work towards prosperity. In a broader context, economic survival involves making informed decisions, managing resources effectively, and adapting to the ever-changing economic landscape (Onyema, 2017). However, when it comes to economic survival in the family, counselling plays a crucial role in helping individuals and families navigate financial difficulties, make informed decisions, and build resilience. The objectives of

Counselling for economic survival is to conduct a thorough evaluation of the family's financial situation and set a goal by assisting individuals and families in defining short-term and long-term financial objectives (Nwosu, 2019)

This can be done by offering guidance on acquiring skills for career advancement or exploring new employment opportunities, providing a supportive environment to address the emotional impact of financial stress and assisting in accessing community resources, government programs, and financial aid (Ajala, 2018). This the Counsellor does by conducting an initial assessment to understand the family's financial situation, challenges, and goals, providing information on budgeting, financial planning, debt management, and other relevant topics. According to Okoro. (2020) and Nwosu, (2019), he empowers families or individuals to take control of their financial situation and make informed decisions. The Counsellor advocates for clients by helping them access available resources and support services, and collaborating with other professionals such as financial advisors, career counsellors, or legal experts when needed.

21st Century Approaches to Economic Survival

Counselling for economic survival in the family is crucial in the 21st century, given the dynamic economic landscape and the challenges families face. Incorporating these approaches into counselling for economic survival can empower families to navigate the complexities of the 21st-century economy, fostering financial stability and resilience (Igbo 2022). It's essential to tailor these strategies to the specific needs and circumstances of each family. Some of the approaches tailored to economic survival in the 21st century are Financial Planning and Budgeting, Income Diversification and Enhancement, Debt Management, Financial Education and Literacy, Savings and Investments, Community Resources and Support among others.

Studies recently carried out have shown that educational attainment increases access to better-paying jobs and promotes upward social mobility. Individuals with higher levels of education are more likely to secure stable employment, earn higher wages, and accumulate assets that improve household living standards. Consequently, families headed by educated individuals are generally better able to meet basic needs

such as food, healthcare, housing, and children's education, thereby strengthening their long-term economic survival (OECD, 2024; James & Maier, 2024).

However, recent studies also demonstrate that education reduces family economic vulnerability by enhancing intergenerational educational mobility. Families in which parents attain higher levels of education are more likely to experience improved financial stability and reduced poverty, particularly among low-income households. Education enables parents to make informed financial decisions, diversify income sources, and adapt to changing labour market demands brought about by globalization and artificial intelligence (Ma & Ma, 2024).

In developing countries, including Nigeria, education contributes to economic survival by promoting entrepreneurship, innovation, and self-employment. Individuals with formal education and relevant technical skills are better positioned to establish small businesses, adopt modern agricultural practices, utilize digital technologies, and create alternative sources of income. These capabilities increase household resilience during periods of economic recession, inflation, and unemployment. However, the positive

effects of education depend not only on school attendance but also on the quality and relevance of education provided.

Furthermore, experimental evidence from Ghana shows that investment in secondary education generates long-term economic benefits extending beyond the individual to the family. Increased educational attainment delays early marriage, improves children's health and cognitive development, and strengthens the economic well-being of future generations, illustrating the intergenerational impact of education on family survival (Duflo et al., 2024).

Theoretical framework

Socio-cognitive theory of Bandura (2004) as a psychological theory is apt in this study because the theory posits that cognitive processes mediate behavioural changes. The behaviour change expected after the psychological counselling is change in perception favouring adoption of self-reliant initiatives for economic survival. A self-reliant approach to empowering citizens in a developing economy is also important in explaining the need to educate the rural families on how to maximize local resources in fighting economic survival. By applying social-cognitive theory, individuals can better understand the psychological and

social factors influencing their economic survival and make informed decisions to improve their economic well-being. Attitudinal change theory by Harvey, Gifford, Maddux, Jordan and Kathan (1985) is also important in this study as its implication in intervention requiring attitude development and change support the

Research Method

Design

The study adopted a pretest-posttest, control group quasi-experimental approach.

Study Area

The study area is Isi-Uzo Local Government Area of Enugu State bordering Benue and Ebonyi States (Isi-Uzo Local Government Area, 2024). The area has 23 autonomous communities including Eha-Amufu, Ikem, Neke, Mbu, Umualor, etc. The largest city in Isi-Uzo is Eha-Amufu, and the capital is Ikem. Isi-Uzo LGA has a projected population of 220,000, with a land mass of about 877km² (339sqm) (Denis, 2020). The people rely heavily on local agribusiness initiative for economic growth. This area was purposively selected based on the researchers' perception of economic stress which affects family relationships, leading to conflict and decreased well-being.

proposition of this study that psychological counselling would impact positively on the economic survival of the participants in this study. This is because attitudinal theory helps us understand how people's attitudes and beliefs impact their economic survival and well-being.

Population of the study

The study's population consisted of families within the twenty three (23) autonomous communities in Isi Uzo LGA in Enugu State, Nigeria.

Study participants

The sample for the study was selected through simple random sampling method. Five out of the twenty-three communities were randomly selected. Cluster sampling method was applied to compose five (5) villages that are similar based on the most cultivated crop produce (Yam, cassava and rice). The sample consisted of 224 participants; (100 are women, 40 are men, and 74 youths out of which 33 are male and 41 are female). The participants were randomly drawn from families in the selected villages.

Instrumentation

Walsh Family Resilience Questionnaire designed by Walsh (2015) was adopted. The reliability co-efficient was computed by conducting a trial test administered to thirty (30) families from the villages that are not part of the study with a Cronbach Alpha reliability index of 0.85.

Data collection procedure

Pretest data was collected from the participants at their different locations after an initial rapport and formal introduction facilitated by the representatives of the women group and youth leaders. This procedure was the same at all the centres (villages). The treatment was administered by the researchers through teaching, modeling and use of illustrations to bring to the participants' awareness of the 21st century approach to economic survival accessible to them. The participant received one session of one hour per week for 12 weeks. At the end of the 12 weeks immediately after the last session, posttest (Walsh Family Resilience Questionnaire

(WFRQ) was administered on the participants. Attrition suffered after data screening is ten (10) percent. The control group was given a training on career choice based on trait and factor approach. The researcher visited the center after the post test to ascertain the extend to which the participants are utilizing what they learnt during the research.

Data analysis

Data was analyzed using both descriptive and inferential statistics. Descriptive statistics such as mean, frequency, and percentage was used to describe the study participants and to answer research questions. Inferential statistics (Analysis of covariance - ANCOVA) was used to test the hypotheses. These analytical approaches were deemed appropriate as they permitted the researchers to examine the initial differences among the participants and the observed differences due to the treatment.

Age

		Frequency	Percent	Valid Percent	Cumulative Percent
Valid	22 – 27	38	18.9	18.9	18.9
	28 – 33	47	23.4	23.4	42.3
	34 – 39	58	28.9	28.9	71.1
	40 and above	58	28.9	28.9	100.0
	Total	201	100.0	100.0	

Gender

		Frequency	Percent	Valid Percent	Cumulative Percent
Valid	Male	67	33.3	33.3	33.3
	Female	134	66.7	66.7	100.0
	Total	201	100.0	100.0	

Education

		Frequency	Percent	Valid Percent	Cumulative Percent
Valid	Secondary and Below	52	25.9	25.9	25.9
	Tertiary	149	74.1	74.1	100.0
	Total	201	100.0	100.0	

Results

Demographic characteristics of the participants show that among the participants; 18.9% are of the age range of 22 -27years, 23.4% are within 28 - 33 years, 28.9% are within 34 – 39years and 28.9%

are within the age range of 40years and above. Based on gender 33.3% are male while 66.7% are female. Based on educational experience, 25.9% persons have secondary education and below and 74.1% have tertiary education experience. The

participants of the study understand simple English language mixed with pidgin used for the focus group discussion.

Research hypothesis one: H_{01}

There is no significant impact of psychological counselling on the economic survival of families in Isi-Uzo LGA of Enugu State.

To determine whether the treatment has a statistically significant impact, the subjects' post-test results on economic survival were examined using Analysis of Covariance (ANCOVA). The pre-test scores were used as a covariate. The analysis's summary is in Table 1 given below.

Table 1: An overview of the Analysis of Covariance (ANCOVA) demonstrating how the treatment significantly impact the post-test score for economic survival of families in Isi-Uzo LGA of Enugu State.

Source	Type III Sum of Squares	df	Mean Square	F	Sig.	Partial Eta Squared
Corrected Model	65877.359 ^a	25	2635.094	148.534	.000	.955
Intercept	573941.362	1	573941.362	32351.693	.000	.995
Pretest	3.061	1	3.061	.173	.678	.001
Treatment	41309.309	12	3442.442	194.042	.000	.930
Education * Treatment	423.219	12	35.268	1.988	.028	.120
Error	3104.621	175	17.741			
Total	1387419.000	201				
Corrected Total	68981.980	200				

a. R Squared = .955 (Adjusted R Squared = .949)

Table 1 indicates that the treatment had a noteworthy significant impact on the economic survival of families in Isi-Uzo LGA; $F_{(12;175)} = 194.042$, $p < 0.05$, partial

$\eta^2 = 0.930$. Thus, the null hypothesis is disproved. Treatment (psychological counselling), thus, had a significant impact on the economic survival of families in Isi-

Uzo LGA of Enugu State. The effect's magnitude indicates that the treatment was responsible for a 93.0% (partial $\eta^2 = 0.930$) change in economic survival of families in Isi-Uzo LGA of Enugu State.

Discussion of findings: The findings shows that the treatment had significant impact on the families' economic survival which agrees with Socio-cognitive theory of Bandura (2004), that cognitive processes mediate behavioural changes in perception favouring adoption of self-reliant initiatives for economic survival. Hence by applying social-cognitive theory, individuals can better understand the psychological and social factors influencing their economic survival and make informed decisions to improve their economic well-being. However, Attitudinal change theory by Harvey, Gifford, Maddux, Jordan and Kathan (1985) also support the proposition of this study that psychological counselling would impact positively on the economic survival of the participants because attitudinal theory helps us understand how people's attitudes and beliefs impact their economic survival and well-being.

The finding of the study also agrees with the report of Agbaje (2015) that the purpose of professional counsellor to a group or an individual is to help the

recipient improve his or her well-being, and to attain rational behaviour, happiness and self-actualization. Through directive teaching and learning experience, the client becomes aware of the need to retain knowledge and maintain a rational and logical pattern of thinking that improves self and economic survival.

Hypotheses two (H₀₂): There is no significant effect of education on the economic survival of families in Isi-Uzo LGA of Enugu State.

Table 1 further shows that among the families in Isi-Uzo LGA. of Enugu State, the level of education was observed to have a significant effect on their economic survival, with $F_{(12;175)} = 1.988$, $p < 0.05$, and partial $\eta^2 = 0.120$. The null hypothesis is therefore rejected. Therefore, economic survival is influenced by the families' level of education which affects the perception of their own ability to survive. The table also shows that the level of education accounts for a 12.0% change in economic survival experienced by families in Isi-Uzo LGA of Enugu State.

This result is in line with the studies of OECD, (2024); James et.al., (2024), that families or individuals with higher levels of education are more likely to secure stable employment, earn higher wages, and

accumulate assets that improve household living standards, thereby strengthening their long-term economic survival. However, Ma & Ma, (2024) agrees with this finding that families in which parents attain higher levels of education are more likely to experience improved financial stability and reduced poverty, particularly among low-income households as well as make informed financial decisions, diversify income sources, and adapt to changing labour market demands brought about by globalization and artificial intelligence. More so, in Ghana an empirical study shows that increased educational attainment delays early marriage, improves children's health and cognitive development, and strengthens the economic well-being of future generations which impacts on family survival (Duflo et al., 2024).

Conclusion:

Psychological Counseling is effective in tuning the study participants' perception towards self-reliant initiatives for poverty alleviation. This outcome is the same for women and youths. The therapy influenced the participant's perception as expressed in their response to the feedback questions that the intervention was worthwhile because, they are now aware of the wells of opportunities around them to harness to improve their

income and thus alleviate poverty among them. In doing this, individuals may gradually recover from poverty, and thereby contribute to the economy of their communities in particular and Nigeria in general.

Therefore, counselling for economic survival in the family is a collaborative and empowering process that addresses both financial and emotional aspects that need to be tailored to the uniqueness of each family as key to creating a sustainable and effective plan for economic survival in the 21st century.

Recommendation:

The study's conclusion has led to the following recommendations:

1. That government should establish accessible Counselling Centers (Community-Based), staffed by trained counsellors, to provide free or low-cost services to families.
2. The impact of the 21st century approach of psychological counselling should be adopted in partnership with local organizations, churches, and community groups to reach a wider audience and leverage resources.

3. Families should be encouraged to understand their uniqueness and work together to enhance their financial resilience, weather economic challenges, and work towards long-term stability and prosperity.
4. The government should create a sustainable and effective plan for

economic survival in the 21st century.

By implementing these recommendations, families in Isi-Uzo L.G.A can access essential psychological counselling services, empowering them to improve their economic survival and overall well-being.

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